

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN HONDURAS

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Honduras, communities discover that the river they drink from, the mountain forest above their village, the coast they fish, or the land their families have farmed for generations has been handed to a project decided far away. An open-pit mine. A hydroelectric dam. An iron-oxide pellet plant. A palm-oil plantation. A tourism megaproject on the coast. A quarry. The first sign is often a survey crew, a bulldozer, a notice of an environmental licence already granted, or the discovery that a protected area's boundaries were quietly redrawn to make room for a concession.

This guide is a practical manual for those communities. It explains, in concrete steps, how the approval system for large projects is supposed to work in Honduras, where the genuine openings are, what documentation actually matters, how to organise, and how to use the levers — domestic and international — that have, at real cost, worked here. It does not promise victory. It promises a clear-eyed method that gives you the best possible chance while keeping you and your community as safe as circumstances allow — and in Honduras, safety is not a footnote. It is the first consideration on every page, because this is, by the count of murdered defenders per person, the most dangerous country in the world in which to defend land and the environment.

You must hear that truth plainly before anything else. In Honduras, opposing a powerful project can cost you your freedom or your life. Defenders have been criminalised — jailed for years in pre-trial detention on charges a United Nations body found arbitrary — and defenders have been killed, among them the Lenca leader Berta Cáceres, murdered in 2016 after opposing a dam, and the Tocoa water defender and councilman Juan López, murdered in 2024 after opposing a mine in a national park. The people who order these crimes often act with impunity, and the violence comes not only from the state but from companies, local power-holders, and organised crime, frequently entangled. This danger shapes every choice in this guide. It does not mean nothing can be done. It means that how you organise — collectively, never alone; visibly, with witnesses; and with protection sought early — matters as much as what you do.

And there is a second truth, equally real and hard-won: communities in Honduras have stopped and reshaped destructive projects, and have freed their imprisoned and won accountability for their dead. The Guapinol water defenders, criminalised and jailed, were freed after a sustained national and international campaign, and the process that shrank their national park for mining has been challenged and, on paper, reversed. The company executive behind the dam that Berta Cáceres died opposing was convicted. A reformist government declared the country free of new open-pit mining. These victories were won by organised communities — often Indigenous Lenca, Garífuna, Tolupán, and Miskito peoples and campesino movements — using their rights, their courage, and powerful international solidarity, and they show that within

Honduras's captured and violent system there is real, if dangerous, space to prevail.

The projects that damage communities in Honduras follow minerals, water, land, and coastline: mining, dams, agro-industry, and tourism megaprojects, often on Indigenous and Afro-descendant territory and in or beside protected areas. What they share is that the people who profit are seldom those who bear the harm — and that the harm, here, has too often included blood.

The Strategic Framework

The core of this guide is a simple idea: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions, and a chain can be broken at its weakest link.** Your job is to find that link and place your community's strength there — collectively, safely, and with allies.

Every large project in Honduras depends on a sequence: it must obtain an environmental licence through the national impact-assessment system; where it affects Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples it must (in law) be preceded by their free, prior, and informed consultation; it must secure land, water, mining, or energy concessions, some requiring congressional or municipal approval; and then it is built. Each stage has documents that must exist and procedures that must be followed. Every requirement is a potential point of failure for the project — and a potential point of leverage for you.

In Honduras the weak links are distinctive. A project that obtained its licence through a defective or fraudulent assessment, that skipped the Indigenous consultation the law requires, that rests on a protected area unlawfully shrunk to accommodate it, or that lacks a required municipal or community consent is legally exposed. A project that has drawn the attention of the Inter-American human-rights system, or of international solidarity, faces a scrutiny the domestic system alone does not provide — and this external leverage, unlike in the world's most closed countries, is live and powerful here. And a reformist legal opening — a mining moratorium, a law restoring protected areas — gives communities something concrete to demand be enforced. Your task is to find which of these links is weakest for your project.

Critical Caveat: Which Situation Are You In?

Throughout this guide you will find honest assessments, because a guide that promised you could stop any project by filing the right objection would be lying — and in Honduras that lie could get people killed. Here is the honest frame.

When a project is privately driven, dependent on a challengeable licence or concession, affects Indigenous or Afro-descendant lands without proper consultation, or intrudes on a protected area, it is genuinely vulnerable — especially with organised community resistance and international accompaniment. Honduras's real victories have this shape: a documented illegality or a violated right; a united, organised community; and national and international allies who raised the cost of the project and the crime.

When a project is backed by powerful economic and political interests entangled with local power and violence, stopping it is dangerous and hard, and protecting the people involved becomes as important as stopping the project. For these, realistic goals include forcing honest assessment and genuine consultation, exposing illegality, winning delay, securing protective measures for defenders, and building the documented record for domestic and Inter-American accountability.

Knowing which situation you are in — and, above all, what danger it carries — is the most important judgment you will make. Much of this guide is designed to help you judge accurately, act collectively, and protect your people while you pursue the project's genuine weak points.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before you do anything, and read the sections on organising and on the tilted system with special care, because in Honduras safety governs everything. Two principles run through every page. First, **collective safety before tactics**: never act alone, seek protection early, make your struggle visible to witnesses and allies at home and abroad, and treat the security of your people as the first goal. Second, **combine the domestic and the international**: your strongest position joins the country's own rules — the environmental licence, the consultation right, the protected areas, the reformist openings — with the powerful external leverage of the Inter-American system and international solidarity that has, in Honduras, made the decisive difference.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot break a chain you cannot see. This section maps the bodies that decide, the journey a project takes, the rules that govern it, the incentives that bias it, and the overseers who matter — including the international ones that, in Honduras, carry unusual weight.

The Bodies That Decide — And What Each One Controls

MiAmbiente / SERNA — the environment ministry. The Secretaría de Recursos Naturales y Ambiente is the central environmental authority. Through the National Environmental Impact Assessment System (SINEIA) and its technical arm, the Dirección de Evaluación y Control Ambiental (DECA), it reviews a project's environmental impact study, classifies the project by risk, and grants or denies the **environmental licence (licencia ambiental)** that most projects require. This licence — how it was obtained, and whether the assessment behind it was honest and complete — is frequently the single most important, and most challengeable, decision.

The sector concession-granters. Mining rights run through the mining authority; hydroelectric and energy contracts through the energy institutions and, for many concessions, the National Congress, which has approved energy and water concessions by decree; land and forest through the agrarian and forestry institutions. A project typically needs one or more of these concessions in addition to its environmental licence, and each is a separate decision with its own legality.

The municipalities. Honduran municipalities hold real power over land use and local consent. Through the open town council (**cabildo abierto**) and community consultations (**consultas comunitarias** or **ciudadanas**), municipalities and communities have formally declared their territories closed to mining or a specific project. A municipal corporation's refusal, or a community consultation against a project, is both a legal and a political obstacle — and one that has been used across the country.

The institutions of Indigenous and Afro-descendant consultation. Honduras has ratified ILO Convention 169, which requires the free, prior, and informed consultation of Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples — Lenca, Garífuna, Tolupán, Miskito, and others — over measures and projects affecting their lands. Where such peoples are affected, the absence or falsification of this consultation is a fundamental legal defect in the project.

The protected-areas authority. The Sistema Nacional de Áreas Protegidas governs national parks, reserves, and water-producing zones. Boundaries, and whether they were lawfully drawn or unlawfully shrunk to permit a concession, are decisive — as the emblematic case of a national park reduced to allow a mine has shown.

The courts and the Public Prosecutor. Honduras's courts and Public Prosecutor's Office (Ministerio Público) are formally independent but are widely regarded as weakened by corruption and impunity, especially in cases touching powerful interests. They are, nonetheless, venues where licences and concessions can be challenged, where environmental crimes and crimes against defenders can be prosecuted, and where — with sustained pressure and international attention — accountability has, in landmark cases, been won.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Knowing the sequence tells you when to act, because each stage has a window and a document.

Stage 1 — Concession and siting. The developer obtains the underlying right — a mining concession, an energy contract, a land or forest allocation — and the project is sited. Where a concession required congressional or municipal approval, or where it touches a protected area or Indigenous land, that approval and its legality are early, high-value targets.

Stage 2 — Indigenous / community consultation. Where Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples are affected, the law requires their free, prior, and informed consultation before the project proceeds. In practice this is frequently skipped, rushed, or faked — and each such failure is a documented violation of a binding right.

Stage 3 — Environmental impact assessment and licence. The developer prepares an environmental impact study, submits it through SINEIA, and DECA reviews it, classifies the project, and issues (or denies) the environmental licence, with conditions. This is the stage with a defined public and documentary role — and the stage most often marred by defective studies, absent public participation, and licences granted despite obvious problems. A citizen opposition (**oposición ciudadana**) can be filed against a licence request.

Stage 4 — Permits, land, and construction. With the licence and concessions in hand, the developer secures remaining permits, finalises land and water access, arranges financing, and begins. Each is a separate decision to test, and land and water access on Indigenous or campesino territory is often where the clearest illegality — and the sharpest conflict — lies.

Stage 5 — Operation. Once running, a facility must meet its licence conditions and environmental standards and is

subject to inspection. A facility breaching its conditions, or operating without a valid licence, is exposed to enforcement, cancellation, and prosecution — a reminder that the fight does not necessarily end at construction.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Decide the Outcome

You do not need to be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that govern your fight:

- **The General Environmental Law (Ley General del Ambiente, Decreto 104-93)** and the SINEIA regulations — the framework establishing the environmental licence, the impact-assessment procedure, public participation, and the protected-areas system.
- **ILO Convention 169** — the binding requirement of free, prior, and informed consultation of Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples, and the standards the Inter-American human-rights bodies read into it.
- **The Municipalities Law and community-consultation practice** — the cabildo abierto and the consulta comunitaria, through which municipalities and communities exercise a real veto in practice.
- **The protected-areas framework, and Decree 18-2024** — the recent law that restores the original boundaries of a national park shrunk for mining and, more broadly, prohibits granting mining rights in declared protected areas, water-producing zones, and coastal tourist areas. Its enforcement is a live demand and a concrete lever.
- **The mining and energy concession laws** — governing the underlying rights and their approval, and the source of many concrete, documentable breaches.

The pattern to hold in mind: the environmental-licence and assessment rules give you procedure and a documentary voice; the consultation right gives Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples a binding veto that is routinely violated; the municipal and community consultations give a local consent that has real weight; the protected-areas law and the moratorium give reformist openings to demand be enforced; and the Inter-American system stands behind all of it.

Follow the Money — Why the System Often Leans Toward "Yes"

Understand the incentives and you understand why the gate so often opens — and why it can turn deadly. Mining, energy, agro-industry, and tourism promise investment, revenue, and private fortunes, and concessions have been granted in waves, especially after the 2009 coup. Officials are rewarded for attracting capital, and some are entangled — through corruption, family, or organised crime — with the very companies they regulate. Protected areas have been shrunk, consultations skipped, and licences fast-tracked to serve these interests, and those who stand in the way have been criminalised and killed. This is not a system with a neutral referee awaiting persuasion on the merits; on a project powerful interests want, the default is approval, and the resistance is dangerous. Your leverage therefore rarely comes from persuading the local decision-maker. It comes from raising the cost — legal, through documented illegality and violated rights; political, through organised community and municipal refusal; and, decisively in Honduras, reputational and international, through the Inter-American system and solidarity that powerful actors here cannot ignore.

The Overseers — Who Watches the Decision-Makers

In Honduras the domestic overseers are weakened by corruption and impunity, but — unlike in the world's most closed systems — the external overseers are strong, engaged, and have delivered:

- **The Inter-American human-rights system** — the Inter-American Commission (IACHR) and Court, which grant **precautionary measures (medidas cautelares)** to protect defenders at risk, hear cases, and have repeatedly turned their attention to Honduras. This is one of the most powerful levers available to a Honduran community, both to protect people and to pressure the state.
- **The UN human-rights presence and mechanisms** — the OHCHR office in Honduras, which has accompanied defenders (including at Guapinol) and provided technical assistance for reform, and UN bodies such as the Working Group on Arbitrary Detention, whose findings have freed defenders.
- **International solidarity and watchdogs** — organisations documenting attacks on defenders and campaigning internationally, and international legal accompaniment that has co-prosecuted crimes against defenders.
- **The domestic courts and Public Prosecutor** — imperfect and often captured, but venues where, under sustained pressure and international attention, licences have been challenged and landmark convictions won.
- **A courageous independent press and a dense network of Indigenous, Afro-descendant, campesino, and environmental organisations** — the movements that have carried Honduras's real victories, at great cost.

These are the overseers your strategy should be built to reach — and, given the danger, the international ones are not a last resort but an early and central part of both protection and pressure.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit, calibrate your expectations honestly — and weigh the danger, which in Honduras is real and sometimes lethal. The patterns below are not official statistics; they reflect how Honduran projects and community resistance have actually gone. Use them to set a goal that fits your situation and to plan for your protection.

Opposing a mining or dam project on Indigenous or Afro-descendant land without proper consultation — winnable, and dangerous. Where the free, prior, and informed consultation required by ILO 169 was skipped or faked, the violation is fundamental and internationally recognised, and organised Indigenous and Afro-descendant resistance — with legal and international accompaniment — has blocked, delayed, and discredited projects. These fights have also been among the deadliest, so protection must be built in from the start. The emblematic case is that of the Lenca defender Berta Cáceres and her organisation COPINH, who opposed the Agua Zarca dam on the Gualdúbarígame (Gualcarque) river, sacred to the Lenca and approved without proper consultation; Cáceres was murdered in 2016, but the resistance ultimately stalled the dam and, after years of pressure, the company executive who ordered her killing was convicted — a result once thought impossible.

Protecting or restoring a protected area intruded on by a concession — winnable on the law, hard in practice. Where a project rests on a protected area unlawfully shrunk to accommodate it, the illegality is clear and can be challenged — and, with the recent law restoring park boundaries and barring mining in protected and water-producing zones, communities now have a concrete legal opening to demand enforced. Implementation, however, has lagged, so persistence and pressure are essential. The defining case is Guapinol, in Tocoa, where a national park was shrunk in 2013 to permit an iron-oxide mine; the community's water-defence committee resisted, and eight defenders were jailed for more than 900 days in pre-trial detention — arbitrarily, a UN body found — before being freed in 2022 after a sustained national and international campaign. In 2024 Congress passed a law to restore the park's original boundaries and bar mining in protected zones, though it awaits full implementation.

Winning a municipal or community refusal (cabildo abierto / consulta comunitaria) — a real and repeatedly used lever. Municipalities and communities across Honduras have formally declared their territories closed to mining or a specific project. This creates a genuine legal and political obstacle and a powerful expression of local will — though the authorities and companies do not always honour it, so it must be defended.

Freeing criminalised defenders and winning protective measures — achievable with sustained pressure. Where defenders are jailed or threatened, national and international campaigning, Inter-American precautionary measures, and UN scrutiny have freed the imprisoned and won protection — as the release of long-detained water defenders showed. This is often the most urgent goal, and it is winnable.

Forcing honest assessment, exposing illegality, and winning delay — the realistic goal for most fights. Even where a project cannot be stopped outright, documenting a defective study, an absent consultation, or an unlawful concession forces process, imposes delay, and builds the record for domestic and Inter-American accountability.

Winning accountability for crimes against defenders — slow, but achieved in landmark cases. Impunity is the norm, but sustained pressure and international attention have produced convictions — including of the company executive behind the dam Berta Cáceres died opposing — establishing that even the powerful are not always beyond reach.

Stopping a project backed by entrenched interests entangled with violence, outright and quickly — hard and perilous. Honesty requires saying that such projects are the most dangerous and the least likely to be stopped fast, and that here the protection of people, the documented record, and the long game of legal and international accountability are the realistic and safer aims.

The pattern across all categories is consistent, and sharper in Honduras than almost anywhere: campaigns that are **collective, well-documented, rooted in violated rights and clear illegality, and joined to strong international accompaniment** have won real victories — while campaigns that leave people isolated and unprotected have paid the cruellest price. The strongest predictor of both success and survival is whether the community organised collectively, sought protection early, and combined its domestic rights with international leverage.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you write a word or gather your neighbours, you must know exactly what you are fighting, who is behind it, where in its chain it is weakest — and, in Honduras above all, what danger it carries and how your community will stay safe. Acting before you know these things wastes effort and can expose people to lethal risk. Spend your first days answering five questions, collectively and discreetly.

The Five Questions

1. What exactly is the project, and where is it in the approval sequence? Has the concession been granted, the Indigenous consultation done (or skipped), the environmental licence issued, or is construction begun? The stage tells you which window is open now and which deadline is nearest. A project still seeking its licence or consultation is far more open to influence than one already built — though even an operating project without a valid licence, or on an unlawfully shrunk protected area, is challengeable.

2. Who is behind it — the company, and who stands with it? Identify the developer and its owners, and, crucially, who backs it: which officials, which local power-holders, which financiers, and whether there are ties to organised crime or a history of violence against opponents. In Honduras this question is not only strategic; it is a security assessment, because it tells you the nature and level of the danger you face.

3. Does it affect Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples or a protected area? If the project touches Lenca, Garífuna, Tolupán, Miskito, or other Indigenous or Afro-descendant territory, the binding consultation requirement is engaged — and its absence is a fundamental defect. If it intrudes on a protected area or water-producing zone, the protected-areas law and the recent restoration decree are engaged. These are among your strongest legal openings.

4. Which decision and which violation are genuinely challengeable? Is the weak point a skipped or fraudulent Indigenous consultation, a defective environmental licence, an unlawfully shrunk protected area, a concession that lacked required approval, or a municipality's or community's refusal being ignored? Usually one link is weaker than the others. Find it.

5. How organised and protected is the community — and what protection can be secured? This question is a matter of life and safety in Honduras. Is the community united or divided? Are defenders already threatened? What protective measures — collective security, international accompaniment, Inter-American precautionary measures — can be sought, and how soon? Judge this honestly and make protection part of the plan from the very first day.

Reading the Answers

Work the five questions together and a picture forms. **A project on Indigenous or Afro-descendant land without proper consultation** points toward the consultation right, the Inter-American system, and organised Indigenous resistance with accompaniment. **A project on an unlawfully shrunk protected area** points toward the protected-areas law and the restoration decree, and a legal challenge with international support. **A licence obtained through a defective assessment** points toward the environmental-licence challenge and citizen opposition. **A municipal or community refusal being ignored** points toward defending that consultation legally and politically. **Any project backed by interests entangled with violence** points toward making protection and international visibility central, alongside the legal and documentary work.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Before you go further, decide together — collectively, as a community — what winning would actually mean, concretely, honestly, and safely. Depending on your situation, a realistic goal might be: stopping the project; forcing a genuine consultation or honest assessment; restoring or defending a protected area; winning a municipal or community refusal and having it honoured; freeing criminalised defenders and securing protective measures; winning delay; or building the documented record for domestic and Inter-American accountability. A goal that fits your situation keeps the community united and focused, and — critically — a plan that centres the safety of your people is not a lesser plan; in Honduras it is the only responsible one. You can raise your ambition as your organisation and your protection grow.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything that follows, and in Honduras it serves a double purpose: it is the basis of every legal and political challenge, and it is a form of protection, because a project and its crimes documented in dated, sourced, organised form — and shared with allies at home and abroad — are far harder to carry out in the shadows. A community that can show exactly what the project is, what the law required, where the process failed, and what threats its people face holds something that courts, prosecutors, the Inter-American system, journalists, and international allies can act on. A community with only fear and anger has far less.

The Mindset: Build a Record for Justice — and for Safety

Approach documentation as if you are assembling a file that a Honduran prosecutor, an Inter-American Commission lawyer, a UN human-rights officer, and an international journalist will one day read — people who can act on concrete,

provable violations and threats. Everything must be dated, attributed to a source, and stored securely in more than one place, including with trusted allies outside your immediate area and, where possible, outside the country. In Honduras, secure backups are not merely good practice; they protect the record — and sometimes the people — against seizure, destruction, and worse.

What to Document

The project itself. Its exact location and boundaries; its type, scale, and outputs; the company and its owners and backers; the stage it has reached; and every official document you can obtain — the concession, the environmental impact study, the licence and its conditions, the consultation record (or its absence), the protected-area boundaries, and any congressional or municipal approvals. The official paper trail is the spine of your case.

The procedure — and its violations. This is the heart of a Honduran challenge. Was the free, prior, and informed consultation of affected Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples carried out — genuinely, before the project, with the real community — or skipped or faked? Was the environmental impact study honest and complete, and the licence lawfully granted? Was a protected area's boundary lawfully drawn, or shrunk to fit the concession? Did the concession have the approvals the law required? Did a municipal or community consultation reject the project, and is it being ignored? Each gap between what the law required and what happened is a documented violation.

The environmental and territorial baseline. Photograph and date the rivers, forests, coast, water sources, and homes as they are now, with locations recorded. Note drinking-water sources and the communities that depend on them, protected areas and species, and Indigenous and Afro-descendant land and its customary use. This baseline shows what is at risk and lets you later prove what changed. Independent scientific and technical assessment gives your observations authority.

The community, the consent, and the impact. Who lives here, who holds and uses the land and water, how the community decided its position, and what the project would take. Where Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples are affected, document their governance and their decision, because their collective consent — or refusal — is legally decisive.

The threats and attacks — carefully and safely. In Honduras this is essential and grievous. Document, with dates and sources, every threat, act of intimidation, criminalisation, attack, and killing connected to the project — who was targeted, by whom if known, and what the authorities did or failed to do. This record protects your people, supports requests for precautionary measures, and builds the case for accountability. Gather it with great care for the safety of those who collect and hold it.

Every interaction with authorities and the company. Keep a dated log of every notice, meeting, consultation, request, and response — who said what, when, and with what document to prove it. This log is both your timeline and, when officials mislead or stonewall, evidence in itself.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Safety governs documentation in Honduras. Keep multiple secure copies in more than one place, including with trusted national and international allies; assume that devices and communications may be compromised, and protect the identities of those at risk. Record dates and sources for everything; prefer official documents, expert assessments, and verifiable facts over rumour. Be accurate and restrained — a file that overstates can be discredited and can endanger — while ensuring that the grave realities of threat and violence are fully and carefully recorded. A rigorous, secure, well-shared file is both the engine of every challenge and, in Honduras, a genuine layer of protection for the people who built it.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section turns documentation into a concrete list of sources. In Honduras many official records are obtainable, and — crucially — powerful international channels stand ready to receive and act on what you gather. Work through these methodically, and safely.

Official Sources and Registers

The environmental licence file (SINEIA / DECA / MiAmbiente). The environmental impact study, the project's risk classification, the licence and its conditions, and the record of any public participation are held by the environmental authority and its assessment system. Obtain them: they reveal the project's claimed impacts, the assessment's contents, and — checked against reality — where the process failed. A citizen opposition to a licence request generates its own record.

La Gaceta and the congressional record. Concessions, decrees, and legal changes — including those that grant a concession, approve an energy or water contract, or alter a protected area's boundaries — are published in the official gazette, La Gaceta, and reflected in congressional records. These establish exactly what was granted and how, and can reveal the irregular decree or boundary change on which a project rests.

The mining, energy, land, and protected-area authorities. The mining and energy institutions hold the concession and contract records; the agrarian, forestry, and protected-area authorities hold land, forest, and boundary records. Use these to map the footprint, trace the rights, and test their legality — and to establish the protected-area boundaries a project encroaches on.

Municipal records and consultation acts. Municipal corporations hold the records of cabildos abiertos and community consultations, land-use decisions, and local permits. Obtain the acts of any consultation that rejected the project — they are powerful evidence of local refusal.

Property and cadastral records. The property registry and cadastre record parcels, boundaries, and rights, essential for establishing the footprint and any unlawful acquisition of Indigenous, Afro-descendant, or campesino land.

Documents You Request

Requests for public and environmental information. Honduran law provides for access to public information, including environmental information. Request the impact study, the licence, the consultation record, the concession, and monitoring data. A refusal or silence is itself significant. Keep every request and response.

Complaints and oppositions as records. A citizen opposition to a licence, and complaints to the environmental authority or the Public Prosecutor, generate official records of what you raised and when — useful evidence in every subsequent channel.

Independent Evidence

Scientific and technical expertise. Honduran and international scientists, hydrologists, and specialists — and universities and technical NGOs — can provide independent assessment of a project's impacts on water, forests, and health that contradicts a developer's study and carries real authority.

Indigenous, Afro-descendant, campesino, and environmental organisations. Honduras has a dense, experienced, and courageous movement — Indigenous councils and federations, Afro-descendant organisations, campesino movements, municipal defence committees, and environmental and human-rights groups — that carry hard-won knowledge of the law, the procedures, the companies, and the dangers, and that can accompany a community and connect it to national and international allies. Connect early, carefully, and collectively.

Human-rights documentation and prior cases. Human-rights organisations and the press have documented many Honduran projects, the attacks on their opponents, and the outcomes. The record of emblematic cases — the dam, the mine, the freed defenders, the won convictions — is a guide to what works, what is dangerous, and who can help. Study the cases that resemble yours.

International Sources and Channels

For a Honduran community these are not a last resort but a central, early resource:

- **The Inter-American human-rights system.** The Inter-American Commission (IACHR) receives requests for **precautionary measures** to protect defenders at risk, and petitions and cases; its and the Court's attention carries real weight with the Honduran state and with companies.
- **The UN human-rights presence.** The OHCHR office in Honduras and UN special mechanisms receive information, accompany defenders, and can bring international scrutiny to bear.
- **International solidarity and legal accompaniment.** Organisations that document attacks on defenders, campaign internationally, and provide legal accompaniment have made the decisive difference in Honduran cases.

Turning Sources into a Case

As you gather, sort everything against the chain of decisions from Section 2, so each document attaches to the stage and the rule it concerns — and keep a separate, secure file of threats and attacks. By the end you should be able to point to a specific decision, name the rule or right that governed it, show where it failed, and document the danger to your people. That is the raw material of every legal challenge, every complaint, every request for protection, and every approach to the domestic and international channels that the rest of this guide describes.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documentation gives you a case; collective organisation gives you power — and, in Honduras, protection. But organising here carries mortal danger, and how you build opposition determines both whether you succeed and whether your people survive. This section is about building resistance that is collective, disciplined, and — above all — as safe as it can be made, through unity, visibility, and accompaniment.

The Overriding Rule: Never Alone, Always Collective, Always Visible

Honduras's real victories were won by organised collectives — Indigenous councils, Afro-descendant federations, campesino movements, municipal defence committees — not by isolated individuals, and this is not only a matter of strength but of survival. Defenders who stand alone and unseen are the most vulnerable; defenders who act as a united, organised, visible community, connected to national and international allies, are harder to isolate, criminalise, or kill. Build collective structures, make decisions collectively and transparently, share leadership and public roles so no single person carries all the risk, and make your struggle visible — to your neighbours, to the country, and to the world. Visibility is protection.

Start With a Strong, Trusted Core — and a Security Plan

Begin with a committed, trusted core, and from the very first day treat security as part of organising, not an afterthought. Agree on your goal and your decision-making; divide roles; and develop, with experienced allies, a collective security plan — how you communicate, how you protect those most exposed, what you do in the event of threats, and when and how to seek protective measures. Assume infiltration and surveillance are possible. In Honduras, a campaign that organises its security from the start protects both its people and its work.

Widen the Circle — and Reach Outward Early

The affected community and its rightful authorities first. Map who is threatened, and work through the community's own legitimate structures — Indigenous and Afro-descendant governance, community assemblies, municipal committees — so that the resistance is rooted, representative, and collective. Where Indigenous or Afro-descendant peoples are affected, their own decision-making is both the foundation and a legal necessity.

Neighbouring communities, movements, and the municipality. Others facing the same company or threat are natural allies, and Honduras's national movements — Indigenous, Afro-descendant, campesino, environmental, and human-rights — bring experience, legal and technical capacity, and reach. The municipality, through a *cabildo abierto* or community consultation, can turn local refusal into a formal act.

National and international allies — early. Given the danger, connect early with national human-rights organisations and, through them, with the Inter-American system, the UN presence, and international solidarity. International accompaniment and precautionary measures are not for after a tragedy; sought early, they are among the strongest protections a Honduran community has.

Choose Tactics That Fit Honduras's Reality

Honduras has a living repertoire of collective action — assemblies, *cabildos abiertos*, consultations, marches, peaceful roadblocks and encampments (*plantones* and *tomas*) — and these have been central to its victories. But every public action carries real and sometimes lethal risk, and the state and companies have responded with criminalisation and violence. So choose tactics deliberately, weighing power against danger.

The strongest campaigns combine channels. **Legal and consultation action** — challenges to the licence, the concession, and the protected-area boundary; citizen oppositions; municipal and community consultations — is the disciplined backbone that creates records and obstacles. **Collective mobilisation** — assemblies, *cabildos*, peaceful marches, and, where warranted and as safely as possible, encampments and roadblocks — expresses and builds community power. **Documentation, media, and international accompaniment** carry the struggle to the country and the world and protect the people. Sequence them so that legal filings, community actions, and international visibility reinforce one another and keep both the pressure on and the shield up.

Whatever the mix, keep it collective and disciplined, keep it framed as the lawful defence of rights, water, and territory, protect the most exposed above all, and never let anyone face the danger alone or unseen. Guard against burnout, trauma, and grief — which in Honduras are heavy — by sharing the load, caring for one another, and drawing on the movements that have walked this path before. Endurance, unity, and protection are how Honduran communities have

prevailed and survived.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal action is the disciplined backbone of a Honduran campaign — but in a system weakened by corruption and impunity, it rarely wins alone, and it is strongest when joined to collective mobilisation and, above all, to the Inter-American human-rights system, which gives Honduran communities a venue beyond the reach of local capture. This section explains the openings. It is not a substitute for a lawyer — and finding trustworthy, courageous legal accompaniment, national and international, is an early and vital task.

The Domestic Openings — Where Projects Break the Law

The Indigenous / Afro-descendant consultation challenge. Where the free, prior, and informed consultation required by ILO 169 was skipped, rushed, or faked, the project rests on a fundamental legal defect. This is among the strongest grounds available, recognised by the Inter-American bodies, and it goes to the heart of a project on Indigenous or Afro-descendant land.

The environmental-licence challenge. If the environmental impact study was defective, false, or incomplete, if public participation was denied, or if the licence was granted despite obvious problems, the licence is vulnerable. A citizen opposition filed against the licence request, and a legal challenge to a granted licence, are concrete tools.

The protected-area challenge. If a project rests on a protected area or water-producing zone unlawfully shrunk to accommodate it, that is a clear illegality — and the recent restoration law, which restores original park boundaries and bars mining rights in protected and water-producing zones and coastal tourist areas, gives a direct legal basis to challenge the project and demand the law's enforcement.

The concession challenge. If a mining, energy, land, or water concession lacked a required approval, was granted irregularly, or breaches the mining moratorium, it can be contested. Concessions published in the official gazette can be checked against the law that governed them.

Municipal and community consultation. A cabildo abierto or community consultation that rejected the project creates a legal and political obstacle; where it is ignored, defending it in law and demanding it be honoured is itself a challenge.

Criminal Accountability

Two criminal fronts matter in Honduras. First, **environmental and administrative crimes** — illegal exploitation, serious environmental damage, and the falsification of documents to push a project forward — can be reported to the Public Prosecutor, and have, in recent cases, produced charges. Second, and gravely, **crimes against defenders** — threats, criminalisation, attacks, and killings — must be documented and pursued, with international legal accompaniment where possible, both to seek justice and to protect the living. Landmark convictions, including of a company executive behind a deadly dam, show that accountability, though slow and hard-won, is not impossible.

The Inter-American System — The Decisive Venue

For a Honduran community, the Inter-American human-rights system is not a distant last resort but a central and early tool:

- **Precautionary measures (medidas cautelares).** Where defenders are at risk, the Inter-American Commission can request that the state protect them. Sought early and well-documented, these are among the strongest protections available — and they also raise the profile and the cost of the project and the threats.
- **Petitions and cases.** Violations of the rights to consultation, to a healthy environment, to property, and to life and security can be brought to the Inter-American Commission and, ultimately, the Court, whose findings carry weight and have shaped Honduran outcomes.
- **The UN mechanisms.** UN bodies — including the presence in Honduras and mechanisms such as the Working Group on Arbitrary Detention, whose opinion helped free detained defenders — are a parallel channel of protection and pressure.

Deadlines, Standing, and Safety

Three warnings. First, **deadlines matter.** The windows to file a citizen opposition, to challenge a licence or concession, and to bring a matter forward are limited; diarise every one. Second, **standing.** Affected individuals and communities,

Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples through their authorities, and municipalities and organisations all have roles; settle early, with counsel, who brings which action. Third — and paramount — **the safety of those who litigate**. In Honduras, lawyers and defenders who challenge powerful projects have themselves been threatened and killed; secure protective measures, work collectively and with international accompaniment, and never let a person carry a dangerous case alone.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Be clear-eyed. Domestic litigation in Honduras can annul a defective licence, contest an unlawful concession or consultation, invoke the protected-areas law, and — with pressure and international attention — win criminal accountability. But the domestic system's corruption and impunity mean it rarely delivers alone, and it can be turned against defenders through criminalisation. Joined to collective mobilisation and, decisively, to the Inter-American system and international solidarity, however, legal action has freed the imprisoned, protected the threatened, restored a park on paper, and convicted the powerful. Treat the domestic legal channel as the disciplined engine, and the Inter-American system as the venue that gives it reach and gives your people protection — and never work either without the other or without security.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file full of documents. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a Honduran prosecutor, an Inter-American Commission lawyer, a municipal council, an international journalist, and your own community in different ways. In Honduras, learning to translate your evidence for each audience — including the powerful international ones — is what gives an under-resourced community reach against a powerful project.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a national park's boundary was quietly shrunk through an irregular process so that a mining concession could be granted inside it, without the consultation of the affected community. That one fact becomes:

- **A legal argument (domestic):** the concession and licence rest on an unlawful boundary change and a skipped consultation, and are void — and the recent restoration law requires the park's protection and bars mining within it.
- **A consultation-rights argument:** the state violated the binding requirement of free, prior, and informed consultation, a matter the Inter-American bodies enforce.
- **An Inter-American argument:** the state failed to protect the rights to a healthy environment, to territory, and to the defenders resisting the project — grounds for precautionary measures and a case.
- **A political and municipal argument:** officials shrank a protected park, against the community's will, to benefit a company — a story of capture that a cabildo abierto and the public can act on.
- **An international-solidarity argument:** a protected national park and a community's water are being sacrificed to a mine, and the defenders opposing it are being threatened — a call the world has answered before.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest documented facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank.

Match the Argument to the Audience

Domestic courts and prosecutors want a concrete, provable violation of a specific law or right, and a defensible basis to act despite pressure. Keep it precise, sourced, and grounded in the licence, the concession, the consultation, and the protected-area law.

The Inter-American system and UN mechanisms want the violation framed against the specific rights and standards they uphold — consultation, healthy environment, territory, life and security of defenders — and, for precautionary measures, a clear and documented risk to named people.

Municipalities and communities want the concrete local stakes — the water, the land, the health, the will of the people expressed in consultation — and a lawful basis to refuse.

The press and international allies want the human and moral story made vivid and true: the river, the park, the community, the threatened and the fallen defenders, the broken law. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof; keep it accurate.

Your own community wants to understand the stakes, the plan, the risks, and the role each person and structure plays — communicated honestly, collectively, and with care for morale and safety.

The Master Frame: "The Lawful Defence of Rights, Water, and Territory"

Across every audience, the strongest frame in Honduras is the same: you are a community lawfully defending your rights, your water, your territory, and your lives against a project built on violated law and violated rights — and the state's own duty, and the international standards it has accepted, require that those rights be honoured and its defenders protected. This frame is accurate; it is legally powerful, engaging both domestic law and the Inter-American system; it is protective, because it casts defenders as rights-holders exercising lawful rights rather than as criminals or opponents of development; and it is the frame the international solidarity that has saved Honduran defenders responds to. In a country where defenders are criminalised and killed, insisting — loudly, lawfully, and visibly — that you are exercising recognised rights is both your best argument and part of your shield.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and visibility, in Honduras, are not only a way to raise a project's cost — they are a form of protection. A community and its defenders who are seen, at home and abroad, are harder to isolate, criminalise, and kill; a struggle documented and told to the country and the world draws the international solidarity and scrutiny that have made the decisive difference in Honduran cases. Media must therefore be used deliberately, in service of both the goal and the safety of the people.

What Coverage Achieves

Coverage raises the political and reputational cost of a project and its backers; it reaches the national movements and international allies who can accompany and protect you; it supports requests for precautionary measures and international attention; it documents threats and attacks so they cannot be hidden; and it builds the public record that constrains what the company and the authorities can do. In Honduras, sustained national and international coverage has helped free imprisoned defenders, win convictions, and force reform — and it has helped keep people alive.

Build the Story Around People, Place, and Proof

The most powerful Honduran stories join a human face and a documented fact: a community defending the river it drinks from, beside the document showing the park was shrunk for the mine; the family of a fallen defender, beside the evidence of the project he opposed. Lead with the people and the place; supply the proof; keep it accurate and true. Prepare clear, repeatable messages — what the project is, whose rights and water it threatens, what law was broken, who is at risk, and what you demand — and share spokesperson roles so no single person bears all the exposure.

Reach Every Layer

Local and community media and communication build the base and keep the community informed and united. **National independent press** carries the struggle to the country and to decision-makers; Honduras has courageous outlets that follow these stories. **International media and solidarity networks** matter enormously and early: a Honduran land conflict, and above all a threat to defenders, resonates internationally and brings the scrutiny and pressure that powerful local actors cannot ignore. **International human-rights and solidarity organisations** amplify, accompany, and connect a community to protection. **Social media and your own channels** document in real time, mobilise, and reach the world directly — powerful, but to be used with care for security, verification, and the safety of those identified.

Discipline and Safety Above All

Be accurate always; one exaggeration handed to powerful opponents can discredit a campaign and endanger it. Stay on message and grounded in rights, law, water, and the safety of defenders. Anticipate the counter-narrative — that defenders are anti-development, criminals, or outside agitators — and pre-empt it by grounding everything in the community's own rights, the law broken, and the local will expressed in consultation. Above all, protect the people: weigh carefully whether and how to identify those at risk, understanding that for some visibility is protection while for others exposure is danger; make that judgment with the people themselves and with experienced allies; and pair public attention with concrete protective measures. In Honduras, the media strategy that works is the one that makes the struggle and its defenders visible to the country and the world — because that visibility is, at once, pressure on the powerful and a shield

for the people.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications create records, invoke rights, put institutions on notice, and — in Honduras — summon protection. Every letter does double duty: it asks for something, and it documents that you asked, so a response or silence becomes evidence. Keep copies of everything, stored securely and shared with allies. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in rights and law — and, where safety is at stake, precise about the risk.

Template A — Request for Environmental Information

To: MiAmbiente / SERNA (Dirección de Evaluación y Control Ambiental) **Subject:** Solicitud de información ambiental — [project / location]

On behalf of [community / organisation], and under the right of access to public and environmental information, I request in relation to [project] at [location]: the environmental impact study; the project's risk classification; the environmental licence and its conditions; the record of public participation; and any monitoring or inspection data. Please provide these within the legal period. If any item is withheld, please state the specific legal basis.

Template B — Citizen Opposition to a Licence Request

To: the environmental authority handling the licence request **Subject:** Oposición ciudadana — [project]

As [affected residents / community / organisation], we formally oppose the environmental licence requested for [project] at [location], on the following grounds: **First**, the project threatens [water source / protected area / community] as documented [attach]. **Second**, the environmental impact study is deficient in that [specific defect]. **Third**, the required [Indigenous / Afro-descendant] consultation has not been carried out / the project intrudes on a protected area [as documented]. We request that the licence be denied and that this opposition be entered in the record, and that we be notified of the decision.

Template C — Complaint to the Public Prosecutor

To: Ministerio Público (Fiscalía del Ambiente / relevant unit) **Subject:** Denuncia — [environmental crime / illegal exploitation / falsification]

We report the following facts at [location]: [describe — e.g., operation without a valid environmental licence; illegal exploitation and serious environmental damage; falsification of documents to advance the project; unlawful reduction of a protected area], evidenced by [dated documents attached]. We request investigation and appropriate action, and that we be informed of the proceedings. [Where relevant: we also report threats/attacks against defenders connected to this project — see attached record.]

Template D — Request for Inter-American Precautionary Measures

To: Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR) **Subject:** Request for precautionary measures — defenders at risk, [community], Honduras

We request precautionary measures for [named persons / community], who face serious and urgent risk of irreparable harm in connection with their defence of [territory / water / environment] against [project]. The risk is shown by [documented threats, attacks, criminalisation — attach dated record]. The State has [failed to protect / been involved]. We request that the Commission ask the State of Honduras to adopt measures to protect the life and integrity of the beneficiaries, in consultation with them, and to report on the measures taken.

Template E — Assertion of the Right to Free, Prior, and Informed Consultation

To: the relevant State authorities / the developer **Subject:** Violation of the right to consultation (ILO 169) — [project]

As [Indigenous / Afro-descendant people, through our legitimate authorities], we state that [project] affects our territory and that the free, prior, and informed consultation required by ILO Convention 169 has not been carried out [/ was not

genuine, for the following reasons]. We demand that the project not proceed absent a proper consultation conducted in good faith with our recognised authorities, and we reserve all domestic and international remedies.

Template F — Petition to the Municipality / for a Cabildo Abierto

To: the Municipal Corporation of [municipality] **Subject:** Request for an open town council / community consultation on [project]

As residents of [municipality], we request that the Corporation convene a cabildo abierto / community consultation regarding [project], which threatens [water / land / health / territory], so that the population may decide its position, and that the Corporation respect and defend that decision. We attach the concerns and evidence supporting this request.

Template G — Letter Demanding Enforcement of the Protected-Areas Law / Moratorium

To: MiAmbiente / SERNA / the relevant authorities **Subject:** Enforcement of [Decree 18-2024 / the mining moratorium] — [project / area]

We call on the authorities to enforce [the law restoring protected-area boundaries and prohibiting mining rights in protected and water-producing zones / the moratorium on open-pit mining] with respect to [project / area], which [lies within a protected or water-producing zone / is an open-pit mining project]. We request the review, suspension, and cancellation of the relevant licences, permits, and concessions as the law provides, and a written response.

Template H — International Solidarity Appeal

To: international human-rights and environmental organisations / allies **Subject:** Urgent — defenders and territory at risk in [community], Honduras

We write from [community], Honduras, defending [water / territory / environment] against [project]. Our defenders face [threats / criminalisation / violence — documented], and [the law / our rights — consultation, a protected area, the licence] are being violated. We ask for solidarity: amplification of our case, support for precautionary measures and international scrutiny, and accompaniment. Attached is our documented account. In Honduras, your attention helps protect our lives.

Using the Templates Well

File important letters so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in rights and law; attach your evidence; and, where people are at risk, be precise and urgent about the danger. Share them with national and international allies. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Honduras that record, and the international attention it summons, are both the engine of your challenge and part of the shield around your people.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes the licence is already granted, the machines have arrived, or — gravely — threats have already begun, and you cannot read this whole guide first. This is the compressed version. Do these things, in this order — collectively, and with safety first.

1. Gather the community and never act alone. The first and most protective step in Honduras is to organise collectively, through the community's own legitimate structures, and to ensure no one faces this alone or unseen. Isolation is danger.

2. Assess the danger and seek protection early. Honestly assess the threat, and begin at once to connect with national human-rights organisations and, through them, the Inter-American system and international allies. Where anyone is threatened, start documenting the threats and prepare a request for precautionary measures. Protection is not for later; it is now.

3. Find out exactly where the project stands, today. Has the consultation been done or skipped, the environmental licence granted, a protected area shrunk, construction begun? This tells you which window is open and which deadline is nearest.

4. File the immediate legal steps, even if imperfect. If a licence is pending, file a citizen opposition before it closes. Request the environmental information — the study, the licence, the consultation record, the concession. If Indigenous or Afro-descendant land is affected, assert the consultation right in writing. These preserve your position and start your record.

5. Photograph and date the baseline, and identify the violated rule. Capture the river, forest, water sources, and homes at risk, with dates. Pin down the specific violation — a skipped consultation, a defective licence, an unlawfully shrunk protected area, a breached moratorium. The specific rule or right is your lever.

6. Convene the municipality and the community consultation. Request a cabildo abierto or community consultation so the population can formally decide and refuse — a real legal and political obstacle that has been used across Honduras.

7. Go public — for pressure and for protection. Get your story, with people, place, and proof, to national and international media and solidarity networks. In Honduras, visibility raises the project's cost and helps keep your people safe.

8. Connect with the movements and legal accompaniment who have done this before. Reach the Indigenous, Afro-descendant, campesino, environmental, and human-rights organisations, and trustworthy lawyers, national and international, who carry the experience, the reach, and the protection a community needs. This single step multiplies everything else.

Do these eight things and you will have organised collectively, begun protecting your people, preserved your legal position, started your record, engaged the municipality, gone public, and connected to the allies and international channels that make the decisive difference in Honduras. Then come back and read the rest — and read the organising and tilted-system sections with special care.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Honduras's system is tilted on projects powerful interests want, and the tilt here has a lethal edge you must understand — so you neither despair nor, above all, expose your people to avoidable danger.

Where the Tilt Shows

Economic and political power are entangled: concessions have been granted in waves, protected areas shrunk through irregular processes, consultations skipped, and licences fast-tracked to serve investors and connected interests. The courts and Public Prosecutor, formally independent, are widely seen as weakened by corruption and impunity, especially in cases touching the powerful, and defenders who turn to them are often criminalised in return. And the tilt is enforced not only by law and money but by violence: threats, criminalisation, forced displacement, and killings, carried out by state and private actors and organised crime, frequently with impunity — which is why Honduras leads the world in murders of environmental defenders per person. Recent moves to fast-track environmental licensing for "strategic sectors" show the tilt reasserting itself even as reforms are won.

What Still Works — And It Is Real

The crucial thing to hold onto is that in Honduras, unlike in the world's most closed systems, powerful levers remain live — and they have delivered.

International leverage is strong and available. This is Honduras's decisive difference. The Inter-American human-rights system grants precautionary measures that protect defenders and pressure the state; the UN presence accompanies and scrutinises; and international solidarity amplifies and shields. These are not distant hopes: they freed imprisoned Guapinol defenders, and international and UN attention has repeatedly changed the course of Honduran cases. Reached early, they are both protection and pressure.

Rights and reformist openings give real legal ground. The binding right to Indigenous and Afro-descendant consultation, the environmental-licence procedure, the protected-areas law that restores park boundaries and bars mining in protected zones, and the mining moratorium are genuine legal footholds — and where the state fails to enforce its own reforms, demanding that enforcement, loudly and with allies, is itself a lever.

Collective community and municipal power works. United communities, Indigenous and Afro-descendant governance, and municipal cabildos and consultations have refused projects and made those refusals stick, especially when defended legally and internationally.

Accountability, though slow, is possible. Impunity is the norm, but sustained pressure and international attention have won convictions even of the powerful, and each such case narrows the space for the next crime. The danger, though, remains grave and current: the Tocoa water defender and councilman Juan López, who had long opposed the same mining project, was murdered in 2024, a reminder that even amid legal victories the violence persists and protection can never be set aside.

The Honest Frame — and the Warning

So the honest frame for Honduras is neither despair nor false confidence, and it carries a graver safety warning than most. Stopping a project backed by interests entangled with violence is dangerous and hard, and it cannot be done safely by isolated or unprotected people. But with collective organisation, early protection, documented illegality and violated rights, and — decisively — the Inter-American system and international solidarity, Honduran communities have stopped and delayed projects, restored protected areas on paper, freed their imprisoned, protected the threatened, and convicted the guilty. The method that works here joins the country's own rights and reformist openings to powerful international leverage, and it places the safety of the people at the centre of everything. Diagnose the tilt and the danger honestly, organise collectively, seek protection early, use every lever together, and never let a defender stand alone or unseen. That is how Honduras's communities have prevailed — and survived.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

In Honduras, corruption is frequently not a suspicion but the visible mechanism by which destructive projects advance — and recognising it matters, because documented corruption is both a deeper danger and a distinct, powerful line of attack, especially when pursued through the international channels that reach past domestic impunity.

Signs of Capture

Watch for the patterns that recur in Honduran cases. A protected area's boundary shrunk through an irregular process precisely so a concession could be granted inside it. A concession or contract approved with unusual speed or on unusually favourable terms. An environmental licence granted despite a plainly deficient study, or public participation and Indigenous consultation skipped or faked. Documents altered by an official to push a project forward. Licences fast-tracked under a "strategic sector" banner that excludes the affected communities. A local mayor, councillor, or official visibly aligned with the company, and enforcement that never comes. And, most gravely, the criminalisation and violent silencing of those who object, with impunity for those who order it. Together these mark a project advanced not on the merits but through capture — and often through the entanglement of officials, companies, and organised crime.

Why This Changes Your Strategy — and Raises the Stakes

Genuine capture makes persuading the local authorities futile, and in Honduras it also raises the danger sharply, because those who benefit are powerful and have shown they will use violence. So this line of attack must be pursued collectively, with protection, and — above all — through the channels that reach beyond the captured domestic system:

- **The Inter-American system and international scrutiny.** Documented capture and the crimes that enforce it are exactly what the Inter-American Commission and Court, the UN mechanisms, and international solidarity are equipped to confront — and their attention reaches where domestic accountability fails, protecting people and pressuring the state.
- **Domestic criminal accountability, pursued with accompaniment.** Environmental crimes, illegal exploitation, and the falsification of documents can be reported to the Public Prosecutor, and recent cases show charges are possible; crimes against defenders must be documented and pursued, with international legal accompaniment, both for justice and for protection.
- **Transparency as attack.** Forcing the underlying documents — the concession, the boundary change, the licence — into the open through information requests and the official gazette strips capture of its cover and often reveals the illegality itself.
- **Enforcing the reforms against the capture.** Where a moratorium or a protected-areas law exists but is being evaded, documenting the evasion and demanding enforcement, with allies, turns the state's own reforms against the captured decision.

Document It Carefully, Collectively, and Safely

If you believe a project is advanced through corruption, document it with rigour, restraint, and acute care for safety, which in Honduras can mean life or death. Distinguish always between what you can prove and what you suspect; allege only what your evidence supports; and be especially careful when the powerful are implicated. Preserve the concealment and the procedural crimes themselves — the irregular boundary change, the faked consultation, the altered document, the licence granted against the evidence — because these hard, specific illegalities are what prosecutors and the Inter-American bodies can act on. Build the file collectively, store it securely and with allies at home and abroad, and share it with the international channels that reach past domestic impunity. In Honduras, documented corruption exposed through the Inter-American system and international solidarity is one of the few forces that has held the powerful to account — and doing this work collectively and with protection is essential to surviving it.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps in this guide are not a menu to pick from; they are strands to weave together over time — collectively, and with protection woven through. This section shows how they combine into a single campaign, and roughly when each comes into play.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

The power of a Honduran campaign comes from combining its strands while keeping the safety of the people at the centre. **Collective organisation** is the foundation and the first protection. **Documentation** feeds everything — the legal challenges, the criminal complaints, the requests for protection, the media, the international appeals. **Legal and consultation action** — the licence challenge, the consultation right, the protected-areas law, the municipal consultation — creates records and obstacles. **Collective mobilisation** expresses and builds community power. **Media and international accompaniment** carry the struggle to the world, raise its cost, and shield the people. **The Inter-American system** protects defenders and reaches past domestic impunity. Each strand strengthens the others: a documented illegality becomes a legal challenge and a criminal complaint; a threat becomes a request for precautionary measures; international attention makes the domestic system act; and the community's unity holds it all together. In Honduras, the international and the protective strands are not additions to the campaign — they are woven through it from the start.

A Rough Timeline

Early (first days and weeks). Organise collectively through the community's legitimate structures; assess the danger and begin seeking protection and international connection at once. Diagnose the project and its stage; identify the weak link and the violated right. File any citizen opposition whose window is open and send your first information requests. Photograph the baseline. Convene the community and, where possible, the municipality. This early phase disproportionately shapes everything after — and in Honduras, the early establishment of collective organisation and protection can be the difference between life and death.

Building (weeks to months). Deepen the documentation, including the secure record of threats. Lodge legal challenges — licence, consultation, concession, protected area — and criminal complaints. Pursue municipal and community consultations. Request Inter-American precautionary measures where people are at risk, and build the international and media presence. Pace yourself; this phase runs for months, and the care of your people through it is part of the work.

Sustained (months to years). Keep the legal, community, media, and international strands alive together, adapting as the project and its backers respond. Maintain the collective and its protection through threats, criminalisation, trauma, and grief — which in Honduras are heavy — by sharing the load, caring for one another, and leaning on the movements and allies who have walked this path. Pursue accountability for any crimes against defenders. Endurance, unity, and protection are how Honduran victories have been won.

Throughout. Reassess honestly and continually — the situation, the danger, and whether the goal still fits. If a lever works, press it; if the danger rises beyond what any outcome can justify, protect your people first: secure them, preserve the documentation with allies, and adapt. Keep the record current, secure, and shared. And keep the safety of your people the first consideration at every step: in Honduras there is no outcome worth a life, and the collective, protected, internationally-accompanied path is the one that has both protected communities and won.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Honduras is, by the measure of murdered defenders per person, the most dangerous country in the world in which to defend land and the environment, and this guide has not pretended otherwise. Its system is captured and violent: protected areas shrunk for concessions, consultations skipped, licences fast-tracked, courts weakened by corruption and impunity, and defenders criminalised and killed. And yet Honduras is also a country where organised communities have stopped and reshaped destructive projects, freed their imprisoned, protected their threatened, restored a national park on paper, won a moratorium on open-pit mining, and convicted the powerful for a defender's murder. Both halves of that truth are real, and holding both — with neither despair nor false hope — is the beginning of wisdom.

On a project built on a violated consultation right, a defective licence, an unlawfully shrunk protected area, or a breached moratorium, an organised community — with legal accompaniment and, decisively, international solidarity and the Inter-American system — has a real chance of stopping or delaying it, and an excellent chance of forcing honest process, protecting its people, and building accountability. On a project backed by interests entangled with violence, stopping it outright is dangerous and hard, and the protection of the people, the documented record, and the long game of legal and international accountability become the realistic and responsible aims. What is never wise in Honduras is to face such a project alone, unprotected, and unseen; the method that works here is collective, protected, and internationally accompanied.

What Distinguishes the Campaigns That Win — and Survive

The campaigns that achieve something in Honduras share a pattern. They organise collectively, through the community's own legitimate structures, and never leave anyone alone. They make safety and protection central from the first day, seeking precautionary measures and international accompaniment early. They document violated rights and clear illegality with rigour, and they combine the country's own tools — the consultation right, the environmental licence, the protected-areas law, the municipal consultation — with the powerful leverage of the Inter-American system and international solidarity. They make their struggle visible, at home and abroad, as both pressure and shield. And they endure, caring for one another through danger, trauma, and grief.

The campaigns that suffer most do the opposite: they leave defenders isolated and unprotected; they rely on a captured domestic system alone; they neglect the international leverage that is Honduras's decisive advantage; or they are worn down and divided before their levers can work.

A Closing Word

If you are reading this because a project threatens your water, your forest, your coast, your territory, or your life, understand that in Honduras you are not powerless — communities like yours have won real victories — but understand equally, and above all, that your safety and your community's safety come first, and that you must never face this alone. The method is clear: organise collectively, seek protection early, document violated rights and illegality, combine your own legal tools with the Inter-American system and international solidarity, make your struggle visible, and endure together. It does not guarantee victory, and it asks you to carry real and sometimes terrible danger. But it is the method by which Honduran communities have protected their rivers, their forests, and their territories, freed their imprisoned, honoured their fallen, and held the powerful to account — and it can protect and empower yours. Judge your campaign by those outcomes, keep your people safe, united, and never alone, and let the courage of those who came before — and the memory of those who fell — strengthen you without ever costing you more than a struggle should.